

Says Singh: "He [Paniker] brought a lot of vitality and vigour into the Madras Art Movement, especially in terms of engaging with South Indian traditions and imagery. And these were the elements that made the Madras artists distinct from any other modern art movement. The Progressives, in fact, were the ones who looked westward whereas the Madras school was the one that was more rooted in Indian thought and tradition."

Paniker's 'Words and Symbols' series of paintings from the late 1960s onwards are a part of *Madras Modern* and they demonstrate the rich fusion of influences and allusions in his work. While Paniker himself acknowledged the role Paul Klee played in his formative years, the artist's mature work took these aesthetic starting points and created something unprecedented and hybrid with them.

Madras Modern: Regionalism and Identity is highly recommended for anybody interested in this vitally important phase in Indian art history. ■

–Aditya Mani Jha

IT

isn't usual to be greeted by jolly First Nation elders from Australia, thousands of miles away in Delhi. But step into the ongoing *Walking through a Songline* exhibition at the Kiran Nadar Museum of Art (KNMA), Saket, and you'll be welcomed by four life-sized displays playing a video on loop of these elders inviting you inside. Presented in collaboration with the Australian High Commission in India, the exhibition (on till July 10) is based on a component of the *Songlines: Tracking the Seven Sisters* exhibition at the National Museum of Australia.

Three-toed footprints of a seemingly mythical creature guide you inside. In the introductory space, a star-spangled night sky is painted across one wall, with the two adjoining walls a patchwork of scribbles and doodles, while a half-solved 1,000-piece jigsaw puzzle occupies a lone table in the room's centre. "The story of the Seven Sisters is one of Australia's most well-known Songlines, which lives on in the stars," reads a plaque, elaborating that the stars on the wall depict the Pleiades and the Orion constellation.

The immersive experience of the multimedia exhibition is continued in the next room; dark behind heavy curtains with a single large display on the ceiling playing a film showcasing a part of the Seven Sisters story. You're encouraged to lie down on the large cushions, and look up at the scenes unfolding above. "We hope that this origin story or what is called the Tjukurpa will resonate with our audience as the song, story and paintings map the primeval footprints of the humans across lands," says Roobina Karode, director and chief curator of KNMA.

The songline tells the story of seven celestial sisters from the Pleiades, and the powerful hunter–Orion–who pursued them. This is showcased in the last room of the exhibition in a trippy display of moving images splashed all over the walls and floor, creating an illusion of movement. Several films projected in smaller alcoves bring the songline together, with the exhibition as a whole portraying how the Seven Sisters remain symbols of resilience and creativity.

"Welcoming or bringing diverse visual/artistic practices to our Indian audience has always been a leading mandate at KNMA," says Karode. ■

–Satarupa Paul

The exhibition is based on a component of the **SONGLINES: TRACKING THE SEVEN SISTERS** at the National Museum of Australia

EXHIBITION

VISIONS FROM DOWN UNDER

An immersive multimedia installation at Delhi's KNMA presents the rich indigenous culture of Australia through a 'songline'





DAZZLING DISPLAYS Exhibits at *Walking through a Songline*, Kiran Nadar Museum of Art, Delhi